

How News Looks When It's Old

EACH YEAR, BIRINYI Associates, the research shop founded by the late Laszlo Birinyi, tracks the most influential media stories and publishes them in a single bound volume.

Scrolling through media stories months later is jarring. Not because the journalists got it wrong—for the most part, they are accurate. But what stands out months or years later is the tone, and how *wildly emotional* it is. With the benefit of time, you see just how *sensationalism* gets embedded in coverage.

Once we know how a story ends—wars, pandemics, takeovers, economic news, legislation, and most of all, market action—the dynamic tension of “What happens next?” is removed. What remains is the panicky zeitgeist of the day.

If you consume news, you must recognize how much infectious sentiment is within the content all along. We learn to our detriment that these passions, overlooked in real time, can be what influences us the most.

Consider Covid-era columns about markets from 2020–21—they have not aged well. Stories you will recall as deeply concerning—back when we all thought washing off our groceries would keep us alive—turn out to be little more than trite speculation. What felt so weighty at the time appears, with the benefit of hindsight, meaningless.

After the zeitgeist passes, all that remains are shrieking headlines. Is it any wonder that investors get distracted or misled?

Consider these three examples: